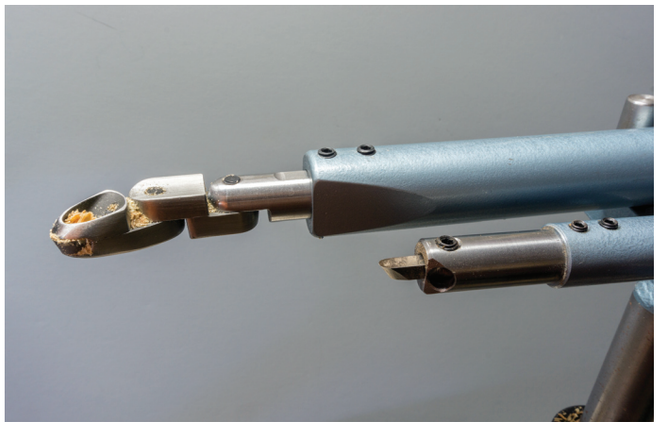
Sizes of a hollowing bar system

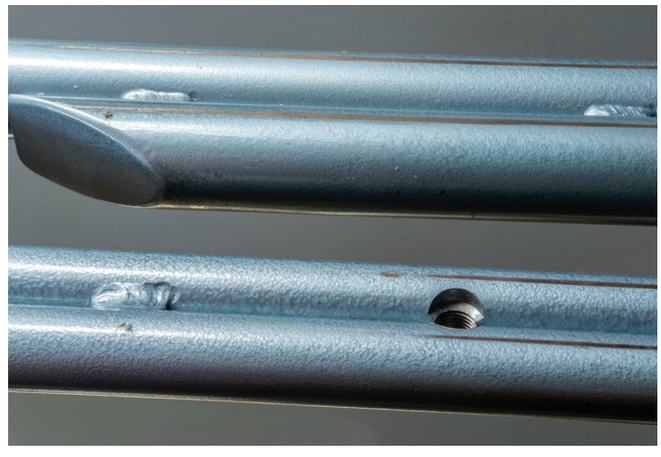
There are many different implementations of 'non-hand-held' hollowing systems. These provide for the capture and control of the back end of the bar via a trap or other mechanical system with the front end riding on a toolrest. The very basic features that the shopper should be aware of are the size of the system and the type. When talking about size, the real key is how deep you intend to hollow and how big is your lathe. Nearly all of the hollowing systems are sized based on the lathe they will be used on. The bar sizes I'm familiar with range from ⅝in to 1¼in diameters. The ⅝in bars are for the depth of about 9in or less while the 1¼in bars are rated for 33in or less. Obviously a table-mounted mini-lathe will be far smaller than something intended for a lathe with a 24in or larger swing. When you are selecting your future hollowing system, pay attention to those that will upsize to a larger lathe. Depending on the manufacturer, you can get toolrests that will fit into a ⅝in mounting and shim to a 1in. Depending on the style, your system may work on a 10 or 12in swing lathe and be able to be adapted to a 24in swing. Of course, the bar size may be a factor if you use your smaller rig on a larger lathe. Remember, the diameter of the bar and the mass will be the main determinant of how far you can reach over the rest as well as how much dampening your rig will provide.



The differences between the ⅝in bar and the 1¼in bar is reach and dampening

Made for smaller lathes, this hollowing rig is capable of about 9in reach over the toolrest

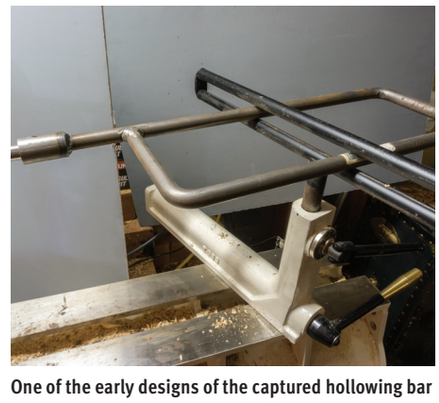
My larger hollowing rig with a 1¼in bar can reach 33in over the toolrest



The dampening of both size systems is considerable with the dual welded bars of ⅝in or 1¼in

Types of hollowing systems

The capture hollowing rig first began as a bar with an outrigger shape to prevent rotation. It worked and still works extremely well. There is a trap at the back that the outrigger travels in and now with a safety catch pin to prevent it from disengaging from the guide trap. An alternative to this design is the side by side welded bar design. It uses the same concept of a trap at the back to support the back end with the side by side bar preventing rotation due to the guide trap. This system also uses a safety locking pin to prevent slipping out of the guide trap. The third common system is a scissors type of system that avoids the need for a guide trap at the back end. It is held at the back with a support post fastened to the bed of the lathe. The front of the hollowing rig uses the same support as the other systems counting on the toolrest to provide the height adjustment for the cutting edge. Which is better? I have systems of all three types and they all work nicely. The scissors types I own are a bit less heavy duty by design and are quite nice to use. For the longest reach, I use my largest dual welded bar design.



One of the early designs of the captured hollowing bar system. Still working well

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